Paper II · Unit II · Topic 1 — Substantive Source-Checked Depth Repair: Early Historic Telangana

Original supplement, 25 October 2026. This supplement strengthens the older shallow published draft. It does not replace or academically approve the original PDF. Sources are official district archaeology and heritage descriptions; dynastic chronology and contested capitals require independent epigraphic review.

1. Reconstructing early Telangana from material evidence

Ancient Telangana cannot be understood simply by memorising a list of dynasties. The region's early history is reconstructed from coins, inscriptions, habitation mounds, brick structures, burial sites, pottery and religious monuments. Each category answers different questions. Coins can indicate circulation, authority or trade, but a coin found in a village does not prove the issuer personally governed that village. An inscription may identify a donor, title or regnal year but usually reflects an elite perspective. Pottery and house remains reveal everyday production and consumption without naming kings. Historians therefore compare evidence rather than forcing every object into one dynastic story.

The Department of Heritage Telangana records excavations at Peddabankur, Phanigiri and other sites, while Karimnagar's district museum exhibits material from Dhulikatta, Peddabankur and Kotilingala. The geographical distribution matters: a network of settlements and monastic sites along routes and rivers indicates exchange and religious patronage, not merely a court-centred civilisation. A mains answer should distinguish an archaeological find, an official heritage interpretation and a hypothesis requiring scholarly verification. Modern district boundaries are administrative conveniences; they were not the borders of ancient kingdoms.

2. Satavahanas: political reach and the problem of a single capital

The Satavahanas were a major early historic Deccan dynasty whose rule and influence extended across areas that today belong to several states. Telangana's Kotilingala, Dhulikatta and Peddabankur are important for studying the early historic landscape. The Karimnagar district history identifies Kotilingala as an early Satavahana capital, but that official heritage formulation should not be mistaken for a settled scholarly consensus on a single capital throughout the dynasty's long history. Capitals, political centres and zones of coin circulation can change across reigns; inscriptions and numismatic sequences require careful comparison.

Satavahana history is inseparable from agriculture, routes, craft production and religious donations. Coins imply monetised exchange in some contexts, while brick-built settlements and Buddhist structures suggest concentrations of resources and labour. Dynastic patronage and merchant donations could coexist; one should not assume every monastery was built directly by a king. The dynasty is often discussed with Prakrit inscriptions, regional language histories and evolving artistic forms, but precise chronology differs across scholarly reconstructions. In an examination, present secure relationships and indicate when an exact date or attribution remains debated.

3. Dhulikatta: stupa architecture and what it reveals

The Peddapalli district's official account describes a Buddhist stupa at Dhulikatta with a circular drum, dome, circumambulatory path and ayaka platforms projecting toward the cardinal directions. Limestone decorative slabs and a Brahmi-inscribed label are part of the archaeological record. The district dates a label palaeographically to around the second century BCE. This does not automatically date every structural phase of the monument to the same year: buildings can be enlarged, repaired and decorated over generations.

The site illustrates how Buddhism was embedded in a settled economy. Construction required craftsmen, stone transport, donors and maintenance; a monastery also depended on food and support from nearby communities. Symbolic representations associated with the Buddha reveal religious visual conventions that differed across periods. The official page uses the term “Hinayana”, but contemporary academic discussion often prefers more precise descriptions of early Buddhist practice because the older label can be polemical or imprecise. Students should identify the architectural evidence first and avoid equating one artistic convention with the beliefs of every resident.

4. Ikshvakus and the Buddhist network of the Krishna valley

The Ikshvakus are associated with the lower Krishna valley and the Nagarjunakonda region, today administratively in Andhra Pradesh, while related Buddhist art and inscriptions illuminate neighbouring Telangana. Modern state boundaries must not obscure the interconnected cultural landscape of ancient trade routes. The Telangana Department of Heritage identifies Phanigiri as a major early historic Buddhist complex and reports a stucco Bodhisattva image in Ikshvaku-period style. A stylistic attribution is evidence of artistic connection, not proof that every patron or monk at the site was an Ikshvaku official.

The network included monasteries, stupas, congregation spaces and donors. Women and non-royal patrons may appear in inscriptional evidence, challenging an exclusively king-centred narrative. Buddhist establishments could receive support from merchants and local households as well as elites. The religious map was plural: Buddhism, Brahmanical practices and Jain traditions existed in different local contexts. For mains, explain the importance of trade, patronage and art together, then add a source-critical note about the limits of assigning a site to a dynasty on the basis of style alone.

5. Phanigiri: excavations, chronology and original objects

Phanigiri in present-day Suryapet district is one of Telangana's strongest archaeological case studies. The state heritage department reports seven excavation seasons between 2001 and 2019 and identifies a congregation hall, chaitya structures, viharas, votive stupas and a substantial group of antiquities. It also records a discovery of thousands of lead coins in March 2024. The excavation dates are dates of modern fieldwork, not the construction dates of the ancient buildings. Similarly, a 2024 discovery of an ancient coin hoard does not mean coins were minted in 2024.

A site can contain multiple occupation phases. Architectural styles, coins, inscriptions and stratigraphic contexts need to be compared before assigning dates. A coin hoard may have been deposited long after the first coins in it were issued. Conservation adds another layer: restored monuments should be distinguished from excavated original fabric. The site's location along historical routes helps explain how Buddhist learning, goods and artistic forms circulated. An effective answer uses Phanigiri to show the relationship between archaeological method and regional cultural history, rather than merely calling it a tourist attraction.

6. Vishnukundins: regional power and religious landscapes

The Vishnukundins belong to the political history of the Deccan after the Satavahana and Ikshvaku phases. Their expansion and cultural influence are discussed through inscriptions, royal titles, settlement patterns and religious foundations. It is tempting to attach every early temple in Telangana to one Vishnukundin ruler, but such claims require dated inscriptions or a defensible architectural sequence. Suryapet district's official heritage account links early construction at Undrugonda with Vishnukundin-era activity; this is a useful lead, not a substitute for a published excavation report.

Religious patronage during this period included evolving Brahmanical institutions while older Buddhist sites continued to shape the landscape. Dynastic succession was not a clean replacement of one population or faith by another. Different centres could rise or decline at different times, and local chiefs or donors could continue practices across political transitions. To explain Vishnukundin history, organise the answer around political geography, inscriptions, religious foundations and cultural continuities. Avoid importing legendary temple narratives as verified dynastic chronology. When a site's attribution rests on tradition, explicitly label it as tradition.

7. Jainism, Buddhism and cultural pluralism

Jain and Buddhist histories in Telangana are often reduced to the names of a few monasteries or statues. A fuller account asks why renunciant traditions attracted patronage, how teachers and merchants moved through the Deccan, and what forms of social organisation sustained religious sites. Buddhist stupas and viharas required donors and communities; Jain images and later centres indicate different strands of devotional and monastic practice. The existence of a monument demonstrates the presence of a tradition, not the religious affiliation of an entire district.

Comparing material culture can reveal both overlap and difference. Sculptural conventions, inscriptions, donor lists and trade routes are more reliable than assuming a continuous line from a modern festival to a specific ancient dynasty. Telangana's State Museum and district collections hold Buddhist and Jain objects, providing opportunities to verify iconography and provenance. A balanced mains answer acknowledges plural patronage, the role of lay supporters and changing artistic practices. It should also avoid a teleological narrative in which one tradition inevitably displaced another everywhere at the same moment.

8. Answer-writing model: evidence before chronology

For a question on early historic Telangana, begin by locating the region within Deccan trade and settlement networks. Next distinguish the Satavahana political phase, the Ikshvaku-connected Buddhist world and the later Vishnukundin period. Use Kotilingala, Dhulikatta, Peddabankur and Phanigiri as named archaeological examples, and explain what their coins, inscriptions, brick structures and sculptures can actually prove. A table comparing material sources is more useful than a long list of unverified dates. End with the importance of interdisciplinary research and preservation.

A high-quality answer also identifies limitations. The administrative claim that Kotilingala was the “first capital” requires comparison with specialist numismatic and epigraphic scholarship. Phanigiri's Ikshvaku-style art should not be conflated with direct political control. Modern discovery dates must not be confused with ancient chronology. This source-critical approach helps students avoid common preliminary-exam traps and produces a credible mains discussion. The existing older PDF remains a draft; this supplement is an additional source, not a declaration that the chapter now meets the requested full-page-per-concept standard.

Official-source register and limitations

- Department of Heritage Telangana, Excavation information and Phanigiri: [open source] (access checked 25 October 2026).
- Karimnagar district, History and Archaeology/Museums: [open source] ; [open source] (access checked 25 October 2026).

- Peddapalli district, Dhulikatta Buddhist Stupa: [open source] (access checked 25 October 2026).
- Suryapet district, Places of Interest (Undrugonda and Phanigiri): [open source] (access checked 25 October 2026).
- Department of Heritage Telangana, Museums: [open source] (access checked 25 October 2026).

Still required: independent academic review of dynastic chronology, original excavation reports, critical epigraphic editions, and a complete substantive replacement of the shallow main PDF. This supplement is not an official TGPSC answer key.